RURAL COMMUNITY

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MEANING OF RURAL COMMUNITY

A rural community is a group of people living together in villages or small settlements outside cities and towns, where the majority depend on agriculture, animal husbandry, and allied occupations for their livelihood. It is characterised by a simple lifestyle, close social bonds, and a slower pace of life compared to urban areas.

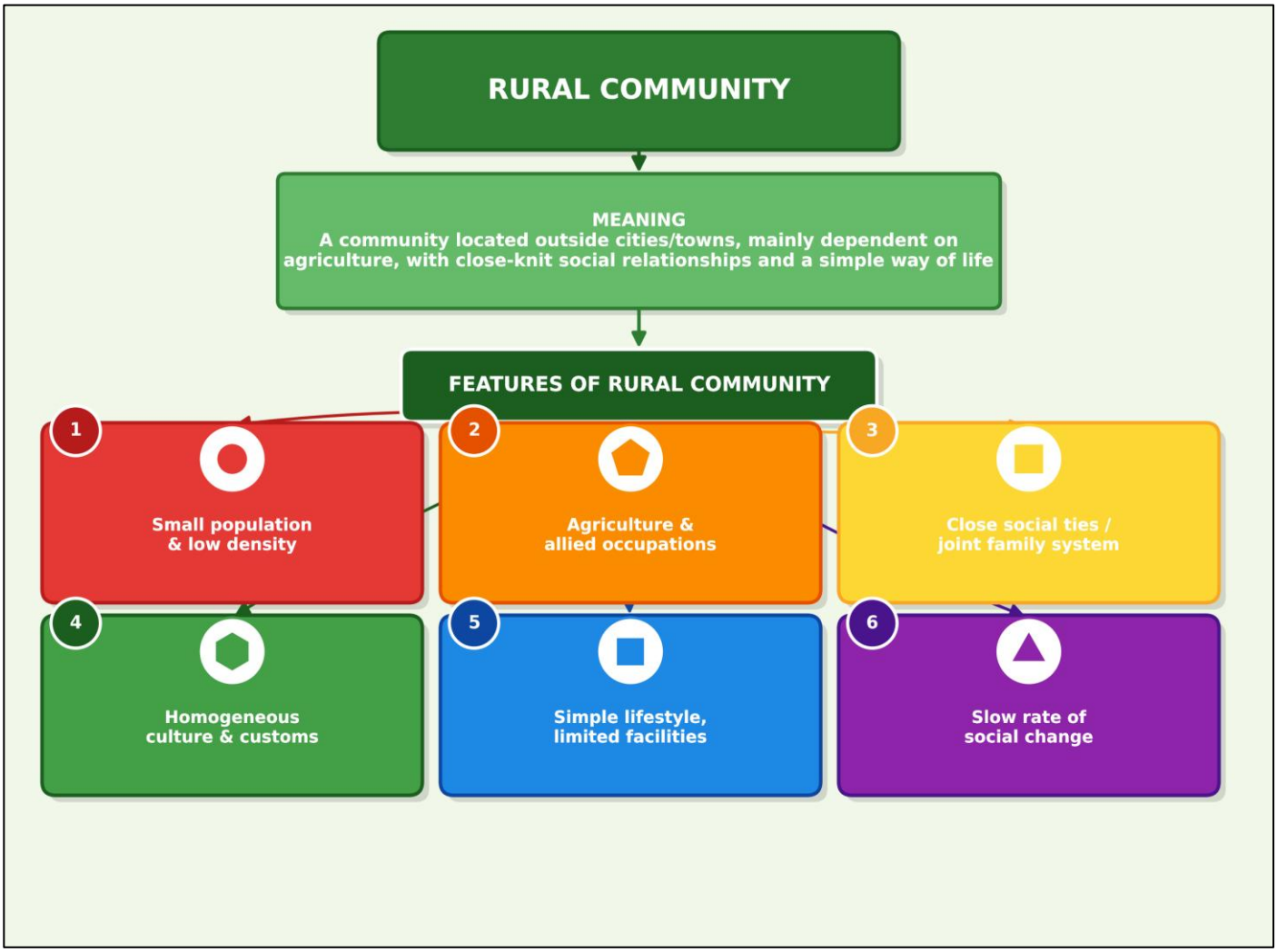


Fig 1 — Meaning and Features of Rural Community

FEATURES OF RURAL COMMUNITY

Feature	Description
Population	Small in size with low density; population is scattered over a wide area.
Occupation	Agriculture and allied activities (animal husbandry, fishing, forestry) form the main occupation.
Social relationships	Primary relationships are strong; joint family system and close kinship ties are common.
Homogeneity	People share common culture, customs, traditions, language and values.
Way of life	Simple living, informal social control, strong influence of religion and tradition.
Facilities	Limited health, education, transport, and communication facilities.
Social change	Change occurs slowly; society is relatively stable and conservative.
Mobility	Low occupational and geographical mobility.

HEALTH HAZARDS OF RURAL POPULATION

Rural populations face a range of health hazards arising from environmental, occupational, nutritional, service-related, infectious and socio-cultural factors, as summarised below.

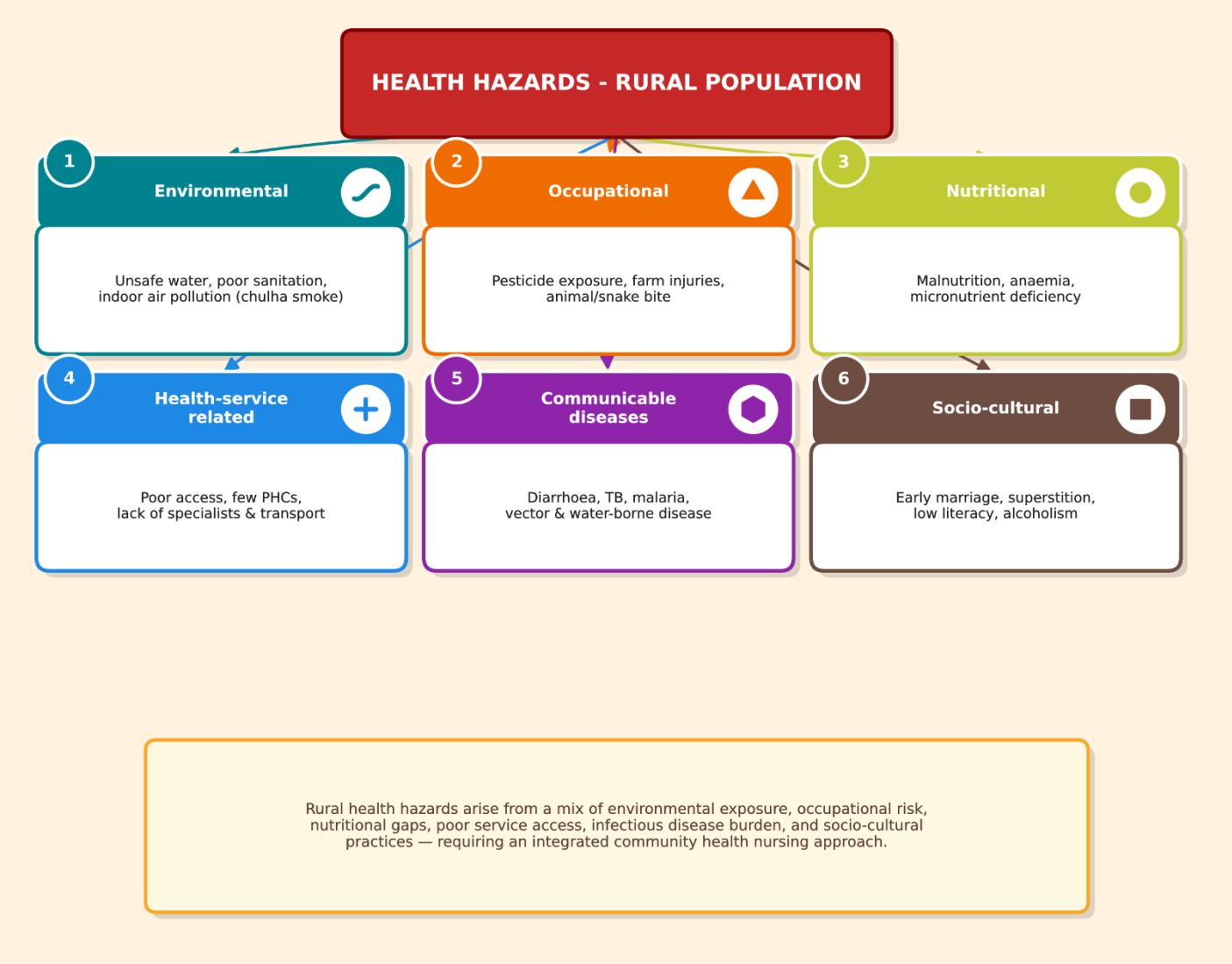


Fig 2 — Health Hazards of Rural Population

Category	Examples / Details
Environmental hazards	Unsafe drinking water, poor sanitation and open defecation, indoor air pollution from biomass/chulha smoke, poor housing.
Occupational hazards	Pesticide and agrochemical exposure, farm machinery injuries, animal-bite/snake-bite injuries, musculoskeletal strain.
Nutritional hazards	Protein-energy malnutrition, iron-deficiency anaemia, iodine and vitamin deficiency disorders.
Health-service related	Inadequate Primary Health Centres/Sub-Centres, shortage of doctors and specialists, poor transport and referral facilities.
Communicable diseases	Diarrhoeal diseases, tuberculosis, malaria and other vector-borne diseases, water-borne infections.
Socio-cultural factors	Early marriage and childbearing, superstition and faith healing, low literacy, poverty, tobacco and alcohol use.

HEALTH HAZARDS TO TRIBAL COMMUNITIES

Tribal communities, living mostly in hilly, forested and remote regions, experience additional health hazards linked to geographic isolation, genetic factors, and distinct socio-cultural practices, over and above the general rural health hazards described above.

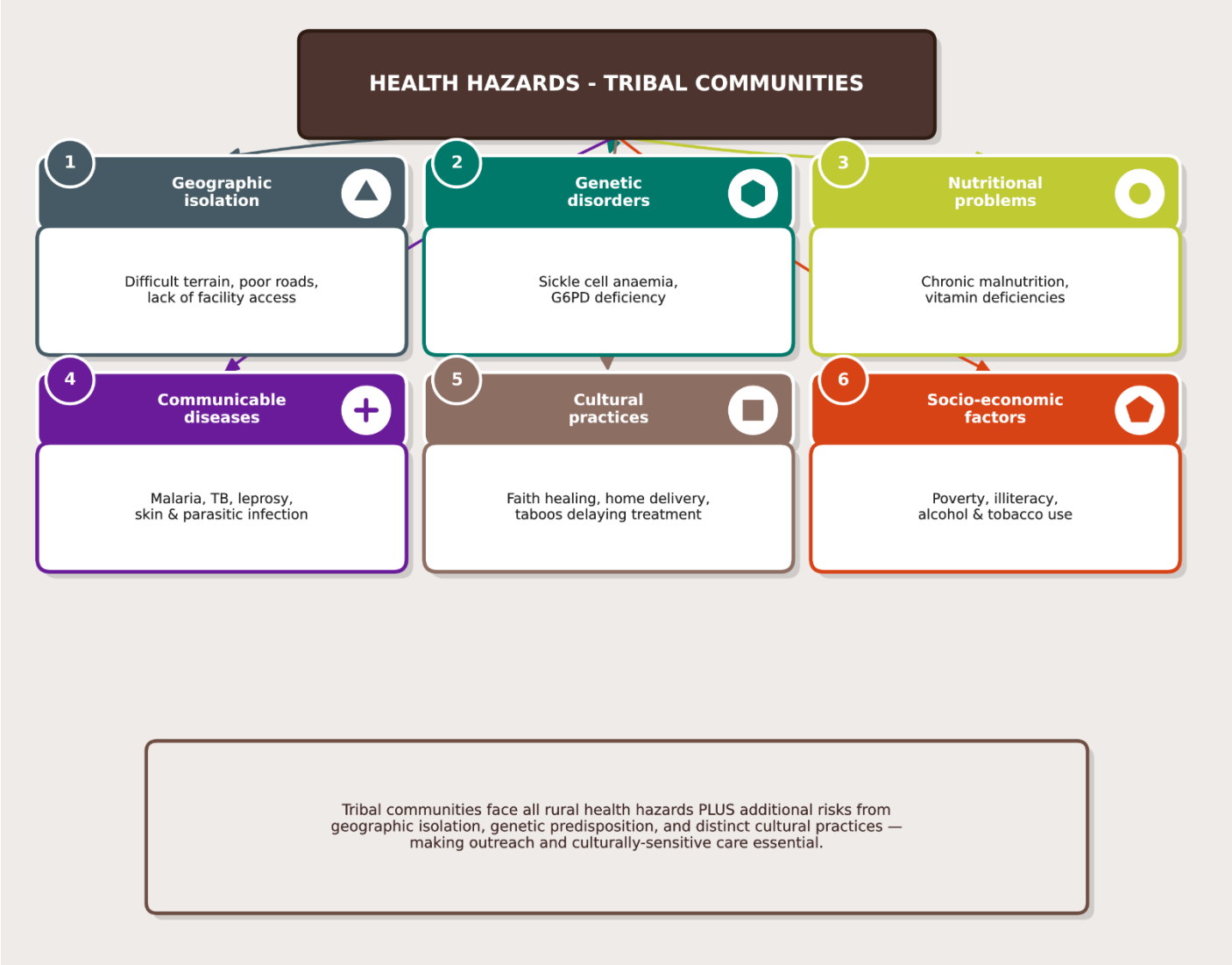


Fig 3 — Health Hazards of Tribal Communities

Category	Examples / Details
Geographic isolation	Difficult hilly/forested terrain, lack of roads and transport, poor access to health facilities and emergency care.
Genetic disorders	Higher prevalence of sickle cell anaemia and G6PD deficiency, partly related to consanguineous marriages.
Nutritional problems	Chronic malnutrition, low birth weight, vitamin and micronutrient deficiencies.
Communicable diseases	High burden of malaria, tuberculosis, leprosy, and skin/parasitic infections.
Cultural practices	Dependence on faith healers/traditional healers, home deliveries without trained attendants, taboos delaying treatment.
Socio-economic factors	Widespread poverty and illiteracy, exploitation, and use of alcohol and tobacco/local brews.

REFERENCES

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